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Democracy Dies in Darkness

MONDAY, SEPTEMBER 29, 2025 • \$4

College funding could be reshaped

White House weighs an edge for schools that vow to align with its priorities

BY LAURA MECKLER AND SUSAN SVRLUGA

The White House is developing a plan that could change how universities are awarded research grants, giving a competitive advantage to schools that pledge to adhere to the values and policies of the Trump administration on admissions, hiring and other matters.

The new system, described by two White House officials, would represent a shift away from the unprecedented wave of investigations and punishments being delivered to individual schools and toward an effort to bring large swaths of colleges into compliance with Trump priorities all at once.

Universities could be asked to affirm that admissions and hiring decisions are based on merit rather than racial or ethnic background, or other factors; that specific factors are taken into account when considering foreign student applications; and that college costs are not out of line with the value students receive.

“Now it’s time to effect change nationwide, not on a one-off basis,” said a senior White House official, who like the other official described the plan on the condition of anonymity because it is still being developed.

Under the current system, the federal government’s vast research funding operation awards billions of dollars’ worth of grants based on peer reviews and scientific merit.

The administration says it is
SEE COLLEGES ON A11



LUKAS KATILIS/AP

A vehicle that was rammed into a Mormon church is surrounded by smoke as a firefighter works on the scene in Grand Blanc, Michigan.

At least 4 dead in Mich. church shooting, police say

BY ANUMITA KAUR AND FAIZ SIDDIQUI

Smoke and flames billowed from a Michigan church Sunday after a man allegedly rammed a truck into the building where worshippers were gathered for a packed service and then opened fire, killing at least four and injuring several others, according to authorities.

Thomas Jacob Sanford, 40, of nearby Burton, was identified by police as the only suspect in the attack on the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints building in Grand Blanc Township.

Grand Blanc Township Police Chief William Renye said 10 gunshot victims were sent to hospitals, two of whom later died. Two more victims were found in the

debris Sunday night after authorities contained a fire that began during the attack and engulfed the church. More victims could be found as authorities search through the rubble from the fire, Renye added.

Police “neutralized” the suspect minutes after the attack began, according to Renye. Police did not respond to questions seeking to clarify how the suspect died. At a news conference Sunday night, Reuben Coleman, acting special agent in charge of the FBI Detroit Field Office, said the FBI is investigating the incident “as an act of targeted violence.”

The shooter’s motive remains unclear, but the attack prompted some major cities, including Los Angeles and New York City, to
SEE GRAND BLANC ON A4



EMILY ELOONIN/GETTY IMAGES

A family reunites at the Trillium Theater across the street from the site of a shooting and fire Sunday in Grand Blanc.

Full force of Trump’s federal job cuts about to hit D.C. area

BY OLIVIA GEORGE, HANNAH NATANSON AND MERYL KORNFELD

The D.C. region is bracing for new economic pain as paychecks stop coming for thousands of federal workers who took the government’s offer of deferred resignation — and the threat of a shutdown could make it worse.

Since January, the region’s unemployment rate has already increased more than eight times as quickly as that of the country as a whole, according to analysis by the Brookings Institution pub-

lished earlier this month. The region has also shed federal jobs at a higher rate, and both the share of residents with low credit scores and the number of homes for sale have grown more quickly than the rest of the country. Meanwhile, private-sector job growth has plateaued.

That’s all before the full effects of President Donald Trump’s cuts to the federal workforce hit. When the fiscal year ends Tuesday night, government workers who have been on paid leave for months will be officially out of their jobs. A prolonged shut-

down, which could also begin this week, could delay pay for remaining federal workers, too — and contractors, who don’t usually get back pay from shutdowns, would suffer as well. The White House budget office told agencies that if the government shuts down they should prepare for mass firings, dealing another blow to the civil service.

“We see a lot of strong early warning signs,” said Tracy Hadden Loh, a fellow at Brookings Metro.

From the loss of federal jobs to changes to federal contracts and

federal real estate, the region has shouldered one blow after another.

For many government employees, the economic danger is already here. In interviews, seven federal workers of varying ages, backgrounds and life stages — all of whom live in or around Washington and took the resignation offer — described a despair-inducing job search saga.

Brian Naranjo, a 55-year-old former State Department employee, said he has unsuccessfully thrown his résumé at more

SEE DOGE ON A10

Parties at a stalemate ahead of key shutdown meeting

Democrats seek to extend ACA subsidies, but GOP says it won’t change bill

BY MARIANA ALFARO

Senate Minority Leader Charles E. Schumer (D-New York) said Sunday that he will use a planned meeting with President Donald Trump and top congressional leaders to insist on including an extension of Affordable Care Act subsidies as part of a deal to avert a government shutdown.

“So far, they stonewalled and said, ‘We’re not discussing any of that,’” Schumer told NBC’s “Meet the Press.” “We’ll see if it changes on Tuesday,” referring to the last day the federal government is funded.

Trump will meet with Schumer, Senate Majority Leader John Thune (R-South Dakota), House Speaker Mike Johnson (R-Louisiana) and House Minority Leader Hakeem Jeffries (D-New York) at 2 p.m. Monday to discuss congressional efforts to avert a government shutdown.

Schumer and Jeffries had insisted that Trump open negotiations, particularly after the president suddenly canceled a scheduled meeting with the two Dem-

ocratic leaders last week, arguing it could not “possibly be productive” because of Democratic demands.

But, over the weekend, Republicans appeared to be far off from agreeing with Democrats’ position. Johnson and Thune remained steadfast in their conviction that the GOP proposal would not be tweaked any further, regardless of any future conversations with Democrats.

Johnson said Sunday that Trump will push Democratic leaders to drop “partisan demands” that would prevent the government from remaining operational when he meets with them at the White House on Monday.

“It’s important to point out the only thing we are trying to do is buy a little time,” Johnson told CNN’s Jake Tapper on Sunday, referring to the Sept. 30 expiration of government funding.

Johnson said any debate on the Affordable Care Act subsidies can be discussed at the end of the year and “not right now, while we’re simply trying to keep the government open.”

Johnson said he spoke with Trump on Saturday and said the president wants to persuade Democrats to reverse course on
SEE SHUTDOWN ON A9

ACA: Funding fight highlights drawback of health care law. A9

Powering the friendly skies on the grease of french fries

BY NICOLÁS RIVERO

Le Diplomate had an emergency. After a week of frying frites, the kitchen at Washington’s famous standby for French cuisine was full of bursting with used grease.

Two waist-high storage tanks in the back of the restaurant sloshed to the brim with dark, viscous oil. During the weekend rush, the staff stored some of the spent grease in plastic tubs, but they were quickly running out of places to put it.

Restaurants are prohibited from dumping grease down the drain because it would clog city

sewers. So on a Tuesday afternoon, James Howell nimbly backed his truck into an alley behind Le Diplomate. He hopped down from the cab and snaked a rubber hose to the kitchen. Then with the flip of a switch and a loud drone, the hose slurped the used cooking oil into the truck’s gleaming steel 2,000-gallon tank.

The spent grease that restaurants unload as waste has become a valuable commodity. If you’ve been on a plane lately, there’s a chance that used cooking oil has helped launch you into the sky. Refineries recycle waste oil into
SEE GREASE ON A18



SCOTT SUCHMAN; FOOD STYLING BY LISA CHERKASKY/BOTH FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Refineries can recycle animal fat and used cooking oil from restaurants to create kerosene pure enough to fuel a jet.

IN THE NEWS

Commanders fall Washington had no answers on defense as it lost on the road to the Atlanta Falcons, 34-27. C1

In Portland As President Donald Trump said he would send troops to a city he has called “war ravaged,” residents greeted his words mostly with confusion. A4

THE NATION
New York Mayor Eric Adams ended his reelection bid as Zohran Mamdani leads in polls. A2
Russell Nelson, president of the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, died at 101. A8

THE WORLD
One million people have returned to Syria since the ouster of Bashar al-Assad, the United Nations said. A12
Russian bombardment left at least four people dead in Ukraine. A13

THE ECONOMY
An Emirati state-backed investment firm stands to win a stake in TikTok’s new U.S. spinoff. A15

STYLE
On TikTok, Pilates is being called a luxury. But instructors say the practice isn’t meant to be exclusive. B1

SPORTS
Europe won the Ryder Cup again, but the Americans managed to make it interesting on the final day. C1

THE REGION
A D.C. charter school will test whether cash payments for students can reduce chronic absenteeism. C11

The Constitution is on public display in its entirety at the National Archives at a time of concern over the document’s staying power. C11

HEALTH & SCIENCE
A mother shares what she has learned about parenting with major depression. D1

BUSINESS NEWS.....A15
COMICS.....B4
OBITUARIES.....C13
OPINION PAGES.....A16
TELEVISION.....B6
WORLD NEWS.....A12

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